



AFTER *BHONSLE* AND *TAANDAV*, THIS IS THE THIRD TIME DEVASHISH MAKHIJA IS DIRECTING MANOJ BAJPAYEE

CINEMA

LABOUR OF LOVE

Devashish Makhija's *Joram*, which premieres at the International Film Festival Rotterdam this year and stars Manoj Bajpayee, is a culmination of years of commitment and patience

About two years ago, when Zee Studios stepped in to back Devashish Makhija's *Joram*, the indie filmmaker felt as if he was being told "*Ja Devashish ja, jee le apni zindagi* (go Devashish go, live your life)!" The 44-year-old filmmaker, screenwriter, graphic artist and author gushes: "It's rare for a big studio like them to back an independent film like *Joram*. Making indie films involves relentless hustle and financial jugglery, but this film was enabled like an independent film should be, though within a studio structure."

Having spent years trying to understand tribal displacement and the correlation between mining and Naxalite issues, *Joram* is the survival story of Dasru (Manoj Bajpayee), a tribal migrant who has moved to a metropolis. Makhija, who wrote and directed *Ajji* (2017) and *Bhonsle* (2018), wrote *Joram* almost a decade ago, but couldn't make it "for many reasons". After *Bhonsle* and the short film *Taandav* (2016), this film is the third time he's directing Bajpayee. "He is the only star you can structure a film around and give any character to play. Most stars have such surreal gym-made bodies that I can't imagine justifying them in a story that's even remotely realistic. Manoj, on the other hand, can be both a 60-year-old *havildar* and an Adivasi." Even after three movies together, the duo work just as hard on every film. "The prep that goes into the look and body language of each character is the same because, for me, it's the most important aspect."

The film premieres at the International Film Festival Rotterdam (IFFR) later this month, where it will compete in the Big Screen Competition. Makhija's previous two films have also screened at IFFR in the past. "My previous films didn't premiere at Rotterdam because the timing wasn't right, and that is something that matters at festivals. Yet, they screened both *Ajji* and *Bhonsle*. As it happens, *Joram* is a week from completion. So it worked out." The IFFR also has an India-focused programme titled 'The Shape of Things to Come?'.

Makhija has already started planning what he will do next. "I'll probably not start a film immediately, but write a novel." He has authored a few bestselling children's books—*When Ali Became Bajrangbali* (2011), *Why Paploo was Perplexed* (2011) and *Forgetting* (2014), an anthology of short stories. "The wait between independent films is interminable. It has taken me four years after *Bhonsle* to make *Joram*. What feeds the hope between films is that I have other media to get my stories out." Having turned producer with *Joram*, Makhija wants to pay it forward by helping other indie filmmakers. "There's a small but sparkling film called *Pokhar Ke Dunu Paar* by a debutant that my producing partner Anupama Bose and I have got the finishing funds for." ■

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